

**Topic B1: Britain,
1830-85:
Representation
and Reform**

The main focus of this topic is on the pressure for parliamentary reform in this period and on the extent to which, in the years to 1884, legislation changed the system of representation in England. Students should understand the nature of pressure for change during the period, the aims and motives of those enacting legislation, and the impact of legislation for representation and for the development of political parties.

The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, students will need to call on their knowledge of the limitations of the reforms of 1832 (bullet point 1) in order to explain the origins of Chartism. The development of party organisation (bullet point 4) is directly linked to the creation of new constituencies and the growth in the franchise. The concept of representation is central to the topic as a whole and an evaluation of the extent to which the parliamentary system became more representative of the people of Britain in the period 1830-85 links all four bullet points.

The first bullet point relates to the Great Reform Act of 1832. Students should understand the system of elections to parliament in 1830, the interests that were and were not represented, the reasons why reform movements were challenging that system and the arguments used by those who sought to defend it. Students should understand why a Reform Act was passed in 1832. They should have knowledge of the nature and extent of pressure for reform in 1830-32 from groups inside and outside Parliament, and of those who resisted change. They should have knowledge and understanding of the roles of key individuals: Earl Grey, Lord John Russell and William IV. Students should have knowledge and understanding of the main features of the Reform Act of 1832 in England, including which aspects of the political system were changed and which remained the same in the period to 1850. Questions will not be set on reform agitation before 1830, although students should understand that the pressure for reform did not begin in 1830.

The second bullet point relates to the nature and significance of the Chartist movement. Students should have knowledge and understanding of why it emerged in the aftermath of the Reform Act and its formation, composition, methods, aims and leadership. In particular they will be expected to know about the contributions of William Lovett and Fergus O'Connor. Students will be expected to consider the nature and extent of support for Chartism and the extent to which Chartism posed a threat to the authorities. Students should understand why the Chartist movement was unable to secure its political demands and why it can nevertheless be regarded as significant in the development of the political culture of working people.

The third bullet point relates to the legislation enacting parliamentary reform in the period 1867-85: the Second Reform Act; the Ballot Act, 1872; the Corrupt and Illegal Practices Prevention Act (1883); the Franchise Act (1884) and the Redistribution Act (1885). Students should have some understanding of why further reform took place in this period. They should have knowledge and understanding of the roles of the main political parties and of individuals in bringing about further reform of Parliament. In particular, they should have knowledge of the roles of Disraeli, Gladstone, Russell and Salisbury. They should also understand the role of extra-parliamentary pressures and interests. Students will not be expected to have detailed knowledge of the clauses of the Acts but they will be expected to understand in what ways and how far relevant legislation impacted upon the representation of groups and interests.

The fourth bullet point relates to the development of political parties in the period from 1832. Students should have knowledge and understanding of the stages by which the Tory/Conservative and Whig/Liberal parties developed their national and local party organisations outside Parliament, and of the increasing party organisation of members within Parliament itself. Students should understand the links between reform legislation and the growth of political party organisation and be able to consider the relationship between the growth of political party organisations after 1832 and 1867 and the influence of the ordinary voter. Students should be aware of the attempts to reach out to new and relatively large electorates, the differing nature of the two party organisations and the ways in which, if at all, party members were able to influence party policy.